

China First-Time Visitor Checklist

A practical pre-trip kit for visa checks, payment setup, apps, internet, hotel addresses, transport, food ordering, and arrival-day backup plans.

How to use this PDF

Work through pages 2-5 before you fly. Screenshot pages 6-7 for taxi, hotel, restaurant, and emergency moments. Use page 8 to verify official requirements before booking.

Best for first-time visitors who want a calmer first day in China, not a packed tourist checklist.

Website: <https://www.firstchinatripkit.com>

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1. Pre-Flight Checklist

Finish these before paying for non-refundable flights, trains, hotels, or activities.

- ☐ Check visa or visa-free transit eligibility with official sources for your passport nationality and route.
- ☐ Confirm your passport has enough validity for airline, hotel, and entry requirements.
- ☐ Book hotels that can register foreign passport holders and save each hotel address in Chinese.
- ☐ Decide your internet plan: roaming, eSIM, local SIM, or pocket Wi-Fi.
- ☐ Install Alipay, WeChat, translation, maps, train, and ride-hailing support before departure.
- ☐ Save flight, hotel, train, insurance, and onward ticket confirmations offline.
- ☐ Tell your bank you will travel and bring at least one physical card for hotel deposits.
- ☐ Pack a compact power bank, medicine basics, tissues, hand sanitizer, and comfortable shoes.

First-trip rule

Do not plan a tight attraction day immediately after a long-haul arrival. Use arrival day for data, payment, hotel check-in, food, and rest.

2. Arrival Day Checklist

The goal is simple: get connected, get to the hotel, make payment work, eat something easy, and sleep.

- Turn on mobile data or connect to airport Wi-Fi before leaving the terminal.
- Open your hotel booking and Chinese address before joining a taxi, ride-hailing, metro, or train queue.
- Check whether your arrival airport or station is far from your hotel; Shanghai Pudong and Hongqiao are not interchangeable.
- Withdraw or exchange a small RMB backup if your payment app is not tested yet.
- Ask hotel staff to write or confirm your hotel address in Chinese for the next taxi ride.
- Test Alipay or WeChat Pay on a low-pressure purchase such as water or a convenience store snack.
- Avoid a prepaid night activity if immigration, baggage, or transfer time took longer than expected.

Taxi phrase	Please take me to this address. Show the Chinese address on page 6.
If payment fails	Try a different card in the app, use cash backup, or ask hotel staff for help before moving far from the hotel.
If data fails	Use airport/hotel Wi-Fi, screenshots, saved addresses, and offline translation until mobile data is fixed.

3. Payment Setup Checklist

China is payment-app friendly, but arrival day is easier when you prepare a backup plan.

- ❑ Install Alipay and add an international card before you fly when possible.
- ❑ Install WeChat and try WeChat Pay if your card and account setup allow it.
- ❑ Keep one physical Visa/Mastercard/Amex for hotels, deposits, and larger merchants that accept cards.
- ❑ Carry a small RMB cash backup for taxis, small shops, or app verification problems.
- ❑ Use a hotel or convenience store purchase to test payment before your first meal or ride-hailing trip.
- ❑ Keep card issuer, SMS verification, and roaming access available for payment security checks.
- ❑ Take screenshots of hotel and train confirmations because ticket desks and hotels may ask for passport-linked booking details.

Common payment mistakes

Relying only on Apple Pay, assuming foreign cards work everywhere, arriving without mobile data, and leaving all backup cards in the same bag.

4. Essential Apps Checklist

Use a small tested setup. The goal is to solve payment, maps, translation, rides, trains, hotels, and food without app overload.

Payment	Alipay first. WeChat Pay as a backup if setup works for your account and card.
Maps	Apple Maps can be useful for English users. Also keep Chinese hotel addresses saved.
Translation	Download offline Chinese packs and test camera translation on a menu screenshot.
Ride-hailing	Prepare a ride option inside Alipay, WeChat, or a dedicated app before late-night arrivals.
Train	Use a reliable train booking channel and save passport-linked confirmations offline.
Hotel	Keep your hotel app, booking confirmation, Chinese address, and phone number easy to find.
Food	Use photos, translation, and simple phrases; do not depend on English menus outside major tourist areas.
Offline backups	Screenshots of passport page, hotel addresses, bookings, emergency contacts, and this PDF.

Before boarding

Open every critical app at least once, check login status, and save verification codes or recovery access where possible.

5. Hotel Address Card Template

Fill this card for each city. Screenshot it and keep it in your photos so taxi drivers, station staff, and hotel staff can help quickly.

Hotel English name	_____
Hotel Chinese name	_____
Chinese address	_____ _____
Hotel phone number	_____
Nearest metro station	_____
Check-in date	_____
Backup landmark	_____

Show this sentence with the address:

Please take me to this hotel/address.	请带我去这个酒店/地址。	Qing dai wo qu zhe ge jiu dian / di zhi.
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6. Emergency Phrase Card

Use short, direct sentences. Show the Chinese characters if pronunciation is difficult.

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
I need help.	我需要帮助。	Wo xu yao bang zhu.
Please call the police.	请帮我报警。	Qing bang wo bao jing.
Please call an ambulance.	请帮我叫救护车。	Qing bang wo jiao jiu hu che.
I lost my passport.	我的护照丢了。	Wo de hu zhao diu le.
I need to go to the hospital.	我需要去医院。	Wo xu yao qu yi yuan.
Please contact my hotel.	请联系我的酒店。	Qing lian xi wo de jiu dian.
I do not speak Chinese.	我不会说中文。	Wo bu hui shuo Zhong wen.
Please write it down.	请写下来。	Qing xie xia lai.

Emergency note

In China, common emergency numbers include 110 for police, 120 for ambulance, and 119 for fire. Ask hotel staff for help if you are unsure.

7. Food Ordering Phrase Card

These phrases help with simple meals, dietary needs, spice level, payment, and takeaway.

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
What do you recommend?	你推荐什么？	Ni tui jian shen me?
Less spicy, please.	请少辣。	Qing shao la.
No spicy, please.	请不要辣。	Qing bu yao la.
I do not eat pork.	我不吃猪肉。	Wo bu chi zhu rou.
I am vegetarian.	我吃素。	Wo chi su.
Can I pay with Alipay?	可以用支付宝吗？	Ke yi yong Zhi Fu Bao ma?
Can I pay with WeChat Pay?	可以用微信支付吗？	Ke yi yong Wei Xin Zhi Fu ma?
Takeaway, please.	请打包。	Qing da bao.

8. Official Verification Links

Use official sources for rules that can affect whether you are allowed to board, enter, stay, pay, ride, or book.

Visa and entry	China National Immigration Administration: https://en.nia.gov.cn/
Consular notices	Ministry of Foreign Affairs / embassy pages: https://www.mfa.gov.cn/eng/
Trains	China Railway 12306: https://www.12306.cn/en/
Your route	Use First China Trip Kit as a planning tool: https://www.firstchinatripkit.com